

# Silviya Nitsova

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Politics Department  
University of Manchester  
Manchester, M13 9PL, UK

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🔗 [Google Scholar](#)

## ACADEMIC POSITIONS

**University of Manchester**, Manchester, UK  
British Academy International Fellow, 2024-  
Politics Department  
*Research Associate,*  
*Mitchell Centre for Social Network Analysis*  
*Cathie Marsh Institute for Social Research*

**National Academy of Sciences of Ukraine**, Kyiv, Ukraine  
Visiting Researcher, 2021-2022  
Institute of Political and Ethnic Studies

## EDUCATION

**University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill**, Chapel Hill, NC  
Ph.D. in Political Science, May 2024  
Comparative Politics, Political Methodology

Committee: Graeme Robertson (chair), Alexander Volfovsky (external), David Szakonyi (external), Cameron Ballard-Rosa, Lucy Martin

**University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill**, Chapel Hill, NC  
M.A. in Global Studies, 2017

**Leiden University**, Leiden, Netherlands  
M.Sc. in Political Science, 2012  
International Relations

**Sofia University “St. Kliment Ohridski”**, Sofia, Bulgaria  
B.A. in European Studies, 2010

## RESEARCH INTERESTS

Political economy, comparative politics, elites, oligarchs, governance, economic and institutional reform, political connections, political networks.

## BOOKS & MONOGRAPHS

**Nitsova, Silviya**, Grigore Pop-Eleches, and Graeme Robertson. 2018. *Revolution and Reform in Ukraine: Evaluating Four Years of Reform*. PONARS Eurasia. 70 pages.

## PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

**Nitsova, Silviya**. 2021. “Why the Difference? Donbas, Kharkiv and Dnipropetrovsk after Ukraine’s Euromaidan Revolution.” *Europe-Asia Studies*, 73:10, 1832-1856.

|                                                                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| UNDER REVIEW                                                   | <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya.</b> Oligarchic Networks of Influence and Legislatures in Developing Democracies: Evidence from Ukraine. <i>Conditionally accepted at American Political Science Review.</i></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>– Winner, Beth Holmgren Graduate Student Essay Prize, Association for Slavic, East European, and Eurasian Studies, 2024.</li><li>– Winner, James W. Prothro Best Paper Award, UNC Political Science, 2024.</li><li>– Winner, Best Doctoral Paper Award, Association for the Study of Nationalities, 2023.</li><li>– Honorable mention, Lubomyr Hajda Graduate Student Paper Prize, American Association for Ukrainian Studies, 2024.</li></ul>                                                |                                                                |      |
| WORK IN PROGRESS                                               | <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya.</b> Divide and Rule: Oligarchic Networks and Patronal Politics. <i>Book manuscript in preparation.</i></p> <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya.</b> War, Oligarchs, and the Conditional Legitimacy of Property Rights. <i>Working paper.</i></p> <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya.</b> Oligarchs and Geopolitical Realignment. <i>Work in progress.</i></p> <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya</b> and John Heathershaw. Oligarchs as Networked Actors: A Relational Conceptualization in Comparative and Global Perspective. <i>Early work in progress.</i></p> <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya</b> and Bilyana Petrova. How Do Attitudes towards Wealth and Economic Redistribution Vary across East European Democracies? <i>Early work in progress.</i></p> |                                                                |      |
| OTHER PUBLICATIONS                                             | <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya.</b> <a href="#">Ukraine's oligarchs are united against Russia. That wasn't the case in 2014.</a> Monkey Cage: Washington Post. April 5, 2022.</p> <p>Conte, Simon, Graeme Robertson, Yuliya Shypilova, Kate Marple-Cantrell, Mariana Akyshina, <b>Silviya Nitsova</b>, and Kostiantyn Gieser. <a href="#">Parliamentary Strengthening in Ukraine: A Field Assessment for Learning, Evaluation and Research Activity II (LER II)</a>. USAID. March 2020. <i>Responsible for survey design and analysis.</i></p> <p><b>Nitsova, Silviya.</b> <a href="#">Applied Field Experience.</a> Duke-UNC Rotary Peace Center. August 2, 2016.</p>                                                                              |                                                                |      |
| AWARDS & FELLOWSHIPS                                           | <p><b>Awards</b></p> <table><tr><td>People's Choice Winner, 3 Minute Thesis, UNC Political Science</td><td>2023</td></tr></table>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | People's Choice Winner, 3 Minute Thesis, UNC Political Science | 2023 |
| People's Choice Winner, 3 Minute Thesis, UNC Political Science | 2023                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                |      |

### **External Research and Academic Fellowships**

|                                                                     |           |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| British Academy International Fellowship, The British Academy       | 2024-2027 |
| <i>£331,285</i>                                                     |           |
| Fellowship, Ronald Coase Institute                                  | 2025      |
| <i>\$2,500</i>                                                      |           |
| Graduate Sabbatical Grant, Institute for Humane Studies             | 2023      |
| <i>\$15,000</i>                                                     |           |
| World Politics & Statecraft Fellowship, Smith Richardson Foundation | 2023      |
| <i>\$7,500</i>                                                      |           |
| Publication Accelerator Grant, Institute for Humane Studies         | 2023      |
| <i>\$5,000</i>                                                      |           |
| Box-Steffensmeier Scholarship, Society for Political Methodology    | 2020      |
| <i>\$2,300</i>                                                      |           |
| Rotary Peace Fellowship, Rotary Foundation                          | 2015-2017 |
| <i>\$47,200 (plus tuition)</i>                                      |           |

### **Internal Research and Academic Fellowships**

|                                                                  |           |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| Summer Research Funding, UNC Political Science                   | 2023      |
| Research Award, UNC CSEEEES                                      | 2023      |
| Graduate Tuition Incentive Scholarship, UNC Graduate School (x2) | 2023      |
| Chair's Top-Up Award, UNC Political Science                      | 2022      |
| Harold J. Glass USAF Fellowship, UNC Graduate School             | 2021-2022 |
| Alumni Excellence Research Fellowship, UNC Political Science     | 2021      |
| Summer Funding Award, UNC Political Science                      | 2018-2021 |
| Davie Circle Summer Research Fellowship, UNC Graduate School     | 2020      |
| Uhlman Research Fellowship, UNC Political Science                | 2020      |
| Summer Research Grant, UNC Global Studies                        | 2016      |

### **Conference Travel Grants**

|                                                                      |      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| Expense Support Grant, Institute for Humane Studies                  | 2025 |
| Travel Grant, American Political Science Association                 | 2025 |
| Travel Grant, University of Oslo                                     | 2025 |
| Travel Grant, Society for Institutional and Organizational Economics | 2025 |
| Travel Grant, King's College London                                  | 2025 |
| Expense Support Grant, Institute for Humane Studies                  | 2024 |
| Professional Travel Award, UNC CSEEEES                               | 2023 |
| Travel & Accessibility Grant, American Political Science Association | 2023 |
| Travel Grant, American Political Science Association                 | 2023 |
| Travel Award, Women's Caucus for Political Science-Midwest           | 2023 |
| Travel Award, UNC Graduate and Professional Student Government       | 2023 |
| Travel Grant, UNC Political Science                                  | 2022 |
| Graduate Student Transportation Grant, UNC Graduate School           | 2022 |
| Hayek Fund Grant, Institute for Humane Studies                       | 2022 |
| Travel Grant, American Political Science Association                 | 2022 |
| Travel Grant, Copenhagen Business School                             | 2022 |

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|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| CONFERENCES                              | <i>Paper presenter (P), Discussant (D), Award winner (A)</i>                                         |      |
|                                          | POLNET Annual Conference. Manchester, UK. (P) <i>Scheduled</i> .                                     | 2026 |
|                                          | SIOE Annual Conference. Fontainebleau, France. (P) <i>Scheduled</i> .                                | 2026 |
|                                          | BASEES Annual Conference. Birmingham, UK. (P)                                                        | 2026 |
|                                          | APSA Annual Meeting. Vancouver, Canada. (P, D)                                                       | 2025 |
|                                          | SIOE Annual Conference. Sydney, Australia. (P)                                                       | 2025 |
|                                          | EPSA Annual Conference. Madrid, Spain. (P)                                                           | 2025 |
|                                          | ASEEES Annual Convention. Boston, MA. (A)                                                            | 2024 |
|                                          | APSA Annual Meeting. Philadelphia, PA. (P)                                                           | 2024 |
|                                          | MPSA, Politics & Political Economy of Eurasia Workshop. Chicago, IL. (P, D)                          | 2024 |
|                                          | ASEEES Annual Convention. Philadelphia, PA. (P, D)                                                   | 2023 |
|                                          | APSA Annual Meeting. Los Angeles, CA. (P, D)                                                         | 2023 |
|                                          | ASN Annual World Convention. New York, NY. (P, A)                                                    | 2023 |
|                                          | MPSA, Midwest Eurasian Political Economy Workshop. Chicago, IL. (P)                                  | 2023 |
|                                          | APSA Annual Meeting. Montréal, Canada. (P)                                                           | 2022 |
| SMALL<br>CONFERENCES &<br>WORKSHOPS      | <i>Paper presenter (P), Discussant (D), Award winner (A)</i>                                         |      |
|                                          | Ronald Coase Institute Workshop. Perugia & Florence, Italy. (P, D)                                   | 2025 |
|                                          | WhoGov Workshop on Political Elites. University of Oslo. (P, D)                                      | 2025 |
|                                          | EPSA Pre-conference on Political Connections.                                                        | 2025 |
|                                          | University Carlos III of Madrid. (P)                                                                 |      |
|                                          | PolMeth Europe. London School of Economics and Political Science. (P)                                | 2025 |
|                                          | Early Career Workshop in Quantitative Political Economy.                                             | 2025 |
|                                          | King's College London. (P)                                                                           |      |
|                                          | Data on Crime and Networks Workshop. University of Manchester. (P)                                   | 2025 |
|                                          | Political Economy Political Science Institutions (PEPSI) Launch Conference. University of Essex. (D) | 2024 |
|                                          | Danyliw Research Seminar. University of Ottawa. (P)                                                  | 2024 |
|                                          | LSE-NYU Annual Conference in Political Science & Political Economy.                                  | 2024 |
|                                          | London School of Economics and Political Science. (P)                                                |      |
|                                          | Women in Legislative Studies Annual Conference. Rice University. (P)                                 | 2022 |
| SELECT<br>INVITED TALKS<br>AND WORKSHOPS | CBS Money in Politics Conference. Copenhagen Business School. (P, D)                                 | 2022 |
|                                          | 14 <sup>th</sup> Annual Rotary Peace Center Conference. UNC-Chapel Hill. (P)                         | 2017 |
|                                          | University of Gothenburg, Comparative Politics/                                                      | 2026 |
|                                          | Quality of Government Seminar. <i>Scheduled</i>                                                      |      |
|                                          | London School of Economics and Political Science, Workshop on                                        | 2026 |
|                                          | Wartime Political Behavior in Russia & Ukraine. <i>Scheduled</i>                                     |      |
|                                          | University of Manchester, D&E AI in Research Workshop. <i>Scheduled</i>                              | 2026 |
|                                          | University of Manchester, Social Statistics Research Seminar.                                        | 2026 |
|                                          | University of Glasgow, CEES Seminar.                                                                 | 2025 |
|                                          | University of Oxford, RESC Politics Seminar.                                                         | 2025 |
|                                          | University of Manchester, Democracy & Elections Seminar.                                             | 2024 |

George Washington University, Contemp. Ukrainian Politics Workshop. 2024  
 UNC-Chapel Hill, Political Power and Persuasion Workshop. 2023  
 Hokkaido University, Slavic-Eurasian Research Center Symposium. 2023  
 Japanese Association of Ukrainian Studies. 2023  
 Copenhagen Business School, Department of International  
 Economics, Government and Business. (online) 2022

RESEARCH

**University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill**

ASSISTANCE

Research Assistant for Lucy Martin and Timothy Ryan, May-Aug 2023.

EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant for Graeme Robertson, 2016-2020.

TEACHING

**University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill**

EXPERIENCE

*Primary Instructor*

POLI 281 Data in Politics: An Introduction, Spring 2024, Spring 2021 (online).

*Teaching Assistant*

POLI 130 Introduction to Comparative Politics, Fall 2022, Spring 2020  
 (partially online), Fall 2019, Spring 2019, Fall 2018.

**Workshops and Guest Lectures**

Designing Empirical Research on Political Networks, half-day workshop (PhD  
 students and ECRs), 19<sup>th</sup> Annual Political Networks Conference, University of  
 Manchester, Aug 5, 2026. *Scheduled.*

Introduction to Social Network Analysis, guest lecture, Research Methods for  
 the Social Sciences (BA, MA, PhD students), Central European University,  
 Invisible University for Ukraine, Dec 12, 2024 (online).

Oligarchic Networks of Influence and Ukraine's Verkhovna Rada since the  
 Euromaidan, guest lecture, Introduction to Public Policy (MA students), Kyiv  
 School of Economics, Nov 13, 2024 (online).

OTHER

PROFESSIONAL

EXPERIENCE

Trainee, Council of Europe Office in Ukraine, Kyiv, Ukraine (2016).

Expert, Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Sofia, Bulgaria (2011-2015).

Trainee, European Commission, Brussels, Belgium (2013-2014).

Short-term election observer, OSCE/ODIHR, Armenia (2013), Albania (2013),  
 Ukraine (2014), Tajikistan (2015).

FIELDWORK

Ukraine (Kyiv), Sep 2021-Feb 2022. Dissertation research. Formal and informal  
 elite interviews.

Ukraine (Kyiv), Jun-Jul 2019. Pre-dissertation exploration. Informal elite  
 interviews.

Ukraine (Kyiv, Kharkiv, Dnipro, Slovyansk), May-Jul 2016. Master's thesis  
 research. Formal and informal elite and non-elite interviews.

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|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PROFESSIONAL<br>DEVELOPMENT       | <p><b>Inter-University Consortium for Political and Social Research</b><br/>Summer Program in Quantitative Methods, University of Michigan, 2020 (online).</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>– Network Analysis: Advanced Topics;</li> <li>– Advanced Bayesian Modeling;</li> <li>– Data Science and Text Analysis.</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| METHODS<br>TRAINING               | Ordinary least squares, generalized linear models, multilevel modeling, social network analysis, causal inference (regression discontinuity, instrumental variables, difference-in-differences), Bayesian statistics, game theory.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| LANGUAGE &<br>TECHNICAL<br>SKILLS | <p>Bulgarian (native), English (proficient), Russian (advanced), Ukrainian (intermediate).</p> <p>Statistical computing in <b>R</b>, Python, Stata, Qualtrics, <math>\text{\LaTeX}</math>.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| LAB<br>MEMBERSHIP                 | <p><a href="#">Authoritarian Politics Lab</a> (UNC-Chapel Hill), 2019-2024.</p> <p><a href="#">Alexander Volfovsky’s Lab Group</a> (Duke University), 2019-2024.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| PROFESSIONAL<br>MEMBERSHIP        | American Political Science Association (APSA), Society for Institutional and Organizational Economics (SIOE), Political Networks (POLNET), European Political Science Society (EPSS), British Association for Slavonic and East European Studies (BASEES), British Association for the Study of Ukraine (BASU).                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| SERVICE &<br>LEADERSHIP           | <p><b>Journal and Grant Review Service</b><br/>Reviewer, <i>American Political Science Review</i>, <i>American Journal of Political Science</i>, <i>Democratization</i>, <i>East European Politics</i>, <i>Europe-Asia Studies</i>, <i>Nationalities Papers</i>.<br/>External Grant/Fellowship Reviewer, <a href="#">ICLD Swedish International Centre for Local Democracy</a>, <a href="#">Rotary Peace Fellowship Program</a>.</p> <p><b>Conference and Association Leadership</b><br/>Co-organizer and Program Committee Member, <a href="#">19<sup>th</sup> Annual Political Networks Conference</a>.<br/>Co-organizer, <a href="#">British Association for the Study of Ukraine National Conference</a>.<br/>Co-chair, Early Career Researchers Working Group, <a href="#">British Association for the Study of Ukraine</a>.</p> <p><b>Expert and Advisory Service</b><br/>Expert, <a href="#">Chapel Hill Expert Survey</a>.<br/>Expert, <a href="#">Data for Ukraine</a>.</p> |

REFERENCES

**Graeme Robertson**

Professor of Political Science  
Department of Political Science  
UNC-Chapel Hill  
[graeme@email.unc.edu](mailto:graeme@email.unc.edu)

**David Szakonyi**

Assoc. Prof. of Political Science  
Department of Political Science  
George Washington University  
[dszakonyi@gwu.edu](mailto:dszakonyi@gwu.edu)

**Alexander Volfovsky**

Assoc. Prof. of Statistical Science  
Department of Statistical Science  
Duke University  
[alexander.volfovsky@duke.edu](mailto:alexander.volfovsky@duke.edu)

**Olga Onuch**

Professor of Comparative & Ukrainian Politics  
Department of Politics  
University of Manchester  
[olga.onuch@manchester.ac.uk](mailto:olga.onuch@manchester.ac.uk)